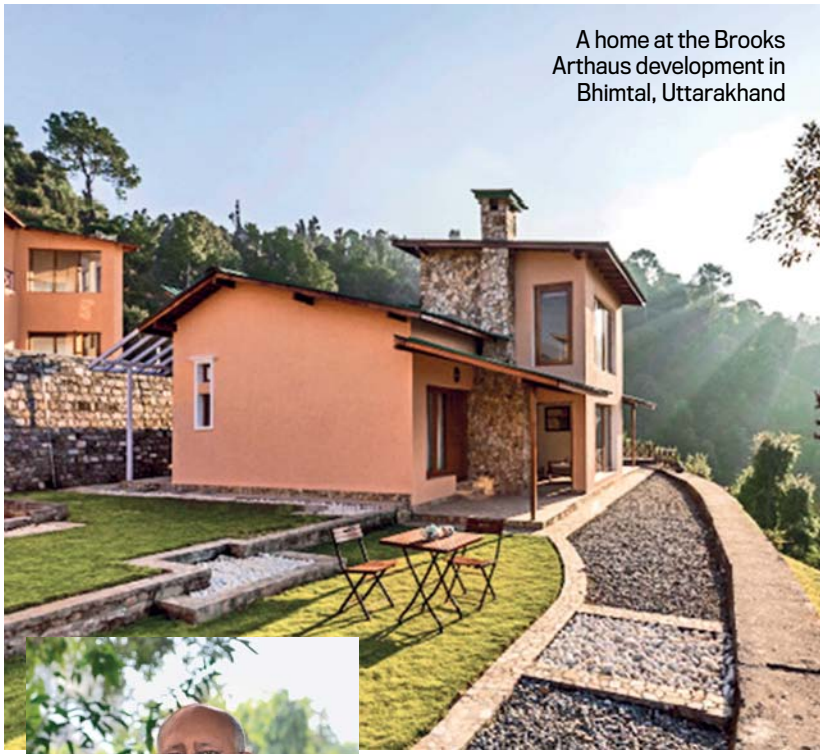


A home at the Brooks Arthaus development in Bhimtal, Uttarakhand



RAJWNAT RAWAT

NITISH MUKHERJEE

Bhimtal, Uttarakhand

"WE WERE LOOKING FOR A SPACE WHERE WE COULD HAVE A STRONGER SENSE OF COMMUNITY, AS WELL AS BE ABLE TO FIT IN EXERCISE AS A NATURAL PART OF OUR DAILY LIFE"

residents. Moreover, apart from the usual suspects—traffic jams, diseases, crime and a high cost of living—the pandemic has brought added stress into people's lives. Dr Kedar Tilwe, a Mumbai-based psychiatrist, says, "Anxiety is common today. Covid has depleted a lot of people's capacities to handle such stress. And so, while traffic might not have impacted someone two years ago, today, people consciously want to move towards a life of less stress, more positivity and relaxation. Stress that is not necessary should be avoided for mental peace and wellbeing." In the TomTom Traffic Index, a global list, Mumbai was ranked second, Bengaluru sixth, Delhi eighth and Pune 16th among 416 cities across 56 countries on traffic congestion.

In Delhi, the unemployment rate is also at a four-month high of 16.8 per cent, according to data for September from the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE). Latest Delhi Police data reveals that street crimes against women, like snatchings and robberies, had increased 30-40 per cent in 2021. "I think the pandemic has rejigged people's focus and a priority for many now is to upgrade their life through better jobs, homes, healthcare, social connections and living spaces," adds Dr Tilwe.

INVESTING IN HAPPINESS

Sharma feels her family has gained more than just a safer, healthier space to live in. They have also flourished professionally. For example, her mother-in-law, an investment and tax consultant, started juggling her professional assignments with teaching local Adivasi children. "We saw how several children at the farm didn't have access to even basic education. We always wanted to give back to society and my mother-in-law saw this as an opportunity to help," says Sharma. The school at Savale village, a short drive from their family home, offers skills-based training to women and children. Sharma quit her job in January this year and is now assisting her husband, Nikhil, with his start-up, a gamified version of a stock exchange for cricket. This new entrepreneurial venture has the couple shuttling between Pune and their new home in Karjat.

The investment in a better quality of life is also evident in the nature of homes people are building outside cities. "No two families are identical and every family comes with its own set of requirements. But the purpose of building a second home is always to create a space to enjoy life away from the hustle and bustle of the city," says Kothari. He also believes that it is important to make sure that there is enough elbow room to feel free and promote oneness with nature. "The major requirements that people have from a second home is that it should be well-lit, well-ventilated and well-connected with the outdoors."

With the pandemic making WFH common and highlighting the importance of health, the second home trend may be here to stay. Driving it is the belief that more positivity can be found away from the chaos of large metros and in more green and healthier places. ■

—with Shelly Anand and Aditi Pai